

Digital Safety for College Students • Session 1: Too Good, Too Fast: Scams Aimed at Students

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

STUDENT COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-linked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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TO VERIFY

Status: **DRAFT for campus review.** Items in [BRACKETS] are local blanks to fill in. Items marked [VERIFY] need a source check. Items marked [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] need review by the college's counsel, Title IX coordinator or student-affairs leadership before use. This is educational material and is not legal advice.

At a glance

SPECIMEN LABEL	
LENGTH	50 minutes
WHO	Students aged about 17 to 24 in first-year seminars, orientation, student success courses, residence life and clubs. Works for groups of 8 to 40.
TOPICS	Fake job and internship offers; rental and housing scams; financial-aid and tuition phishing; textbook, ticket and marketplace scams.
LED BY	A trained facilitator (faculty, staff, peer educator) with a campus counselor or advocate on call for Sessions 5 and 6
MATERIALS	Slides for Session 1 (notes include the script); Scenario cards 1A to 1F, printed, one set per table of 3 or 4; Pause-Check-Tell worksheet, one per table; Campus Safety Card, one per student; Evaluation card, one per student; Local resource sheet with the blanks filled in

NO STUDENT ACCOUNTS, NO student data collected, ever. The evaluation card is anonymous.

Objectives

By the end of the session, students can:

- Name four scam patterns that are common on campuses and describe how each one starts.
- Point to the pressure signals in a message: hurry, secrecy, an unusual way to pay, an offer that is too good, borrowed authority.
- Use Pause, Check, Tell with a second channel you chose yourself.
- State what to do in the first hour after paying or sharing information by mistake.

Before you start (about 20 minutes of prep)

- ☐ Fill in the local blanks on the Campus Safety Card and the resource slide.
- ☐ Ask the financial aid office how it contacts students about balances, refunds and holds, and write that down for slide 5. [LOCAL]
- ☐ Ask the housing office whether it keeps a list of verified off-campus listings. [LOCAL]
- ☐ Read card 1F twice. It involves immigration fear, and you need to be ready for questions you cannot answer. Have the international student office's details on hand.
- ☐ Read the master disclosure protocol in the Facilitator Guide and the session-specific notes below.
- ☐ Print the Campus Safety Card with local blanks filled in.

Agenda

MINUTES	SEGMENT
0 to 5	Open: why this, why you
5 to 13	Four patterns you will see
13 to 21	The anatomy of the pitch, and Pause, Check, Tell
21 to 36	Activity: Six Offers on the Table
36 to 44	Discussion
44 to 50	Takeaway and evaluation card

Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. In this module the idea has the same four steps for adults. Hackles up is the noticing step: a prickle that something is too good, too urgent, too secret or just a little off. Pause means nothing has to happen in the next five minutes. Check means confirming through a door you opened yourself, such as a known phone number or the official app.

Tell means bringing in a person; a false alarm costs little, and if you were fooled anyway it is never your fault.

Facilitator script

LINES IN THE SCRIPT are written to be said in your own voice. Change the words freely; keep the facts. Items in [BRACKETS] are local.

0 TO 5 MINUTES: OPEN: WHY THIS, WHY YOU

Welcome. Over six sessions we will cover the digital situations that come up for people in college, and today we start with money. I want to say up front that nobody in this room is gullible. People who run these scams do it as a job. They test messages on thousands of people and keep the ones that work.

Why students? Think about your first weeks here. You are using a bursar portal, a learning system, a housing office, a financial aid office and maybe a campus job site, many of them for the first time. You get real messages from all of them. A fake one fits right in. Money is tight for many of us, deadlines are real, and a message that says "your classes will be dropped in two hours" sounds plausible because some real deadlines do feel like that.

Here is the habit we will use all semester. Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. Hackles are what rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. Today I want you to treat that prickle as information. You do not have to be right every time. A false alarm costs you two minutes. Being fooled can cost a semester's budget.

Two housekeeping notes. First, take what is useful and pass on anything you would rather not do. Second, if something we cover today has already happened to you, you will not be in trouble here. I will say more at the end about who you can talk to, and about what I can and cannot keep private.

5 TO 13 MINUTES: FOUR PATTERNS YOU WILL SEE

Pattern one, fake jobs and internships. The post is remote, the pay is high for the work, and the interview happens entirely in a chat app. After a quick "hire," you get a check and are told to deposit it and buy equipment from a vendor they name. The check bounces days later and your money is gone. Other versions ask for your Social Security number and bank details for "payroll" before any real paperwork. The rule that protects you: a real employer does not ask you to pay to be hired, and does not send you money to send on to someone else. Check the company through its own website, and ask [CAREER SERVICES] to look at an offer with you. They do this all the time.

Pattern two, housing. The listing is a beautiful two-bedroom near campus at half the going rate. The landlord is traveling and cannot show it, but will

mail the keys once you send a deposit by a payment app or gift cards. Ask yourself why anyone would need the money before you can see the place. Use [HOUSING OFFICE] listings where you can, tour the unit in person or on a live video call that shows the address, and be wary when the only payment options are ones you cannot reverse.

Pattern three, financial aid and tuition. A text arrives that looks like it is from the bursar: pay a balance in two hours or lose your registration. Or a call says your aid refund is ready and asks you to read back a code that was just texted to you. That code is the key to your account, and the caller is the one using it. Real offices have real deadlines, but they do not demand payment by gift card, and they do not ask for the code they just texted you. Go to the portal by typing the address yourself, or call the number printed on the college's website. Also, filling out the federal aid application is free [VERIFY: studentaid.gov], and anyone charging a fee to file it or promising loan forgiveness for a fee deserves a second look [VERIFY].

Pattern four, marketplace. Textbooks, tickets, sublets, furniture. The buyer "accidentally" sends too much and asks you to refund the difference. The seller wants "friends and family" payment so there is no protection. The ticket is a screenshot. Use the platform's own payment protections, transfer tickets through the official ticketing app, and meet in a public place or at [CAMPUS SAFE EXCHANGE SPOT, if any].

13 TO 21 MINUTES: THE ANATOMY OF THE PITCH, AND PAUSE, CHECK, TELL

Look across those four patterns. The details change but the pressure signals repeat. Hurry: act in two hours. Secrecy: do not tell your roommate or the office. An unusual way to pay: gift cards, crypto, wire, a payment app that will not let you reverse it. An offer that is too good. And borrowed authority: the logo, the name of a real office, an official-sounding title.

Now the routine. Hackles up: say to yourself what is off, in words. "They want money before I have seen the apartment." Pause: nothing here has to happen in the next five minutes, and you can say that to a pushy person. For money, I suggest an overnight rule. Check: confirm through a door you opened. That means the official website you typed, the phone number printed on the back of your card or on the college's site, or the office itself. A reply to the same message is not a check, because the sender controls that conversation. Tell: a roommate, [FINANCIAL AID OFFICE], [CAREER SERVICES], campus police at [NON-EMERGENCY NUMBER], and then a report if it was a scam attempt, because reports help other people. In the U.S., fraud goes to reportfraud.ftc.gov, and internet crime can go to ic3.gov [VERIFY]. If your identity information was shared, identitytheft.gov is the FTC's recovery site [VERIFY].

If you already paid or shared something, here is the first hour. Call your bank or card issuer using the number on your card, say what happened, and ask what can be done. Timing and protections vary by payment method [VERIFY]. Change passwords on any account that might be affected, starting with email. Keep the messages and receipts. Then tell someone. Shame is the scammer's best friend, because it keeps you quiet while the next student gets the same message. It is not your fault.

Activity (15 minutes): Six Offers on the Table

Set-up

- Groups of 3 or 4. Each group gets two cards and one worksheet.
- Roles inside the group, rotating after each card: Reader (reads the card aloud, or passes it to a screen reader), Checker (names the second channel), Recorder (fills the worksheet).
- Nobody plays the sender of any message. The card is the message. Students respond as themselves, as a friend, or as a neighbor in the dorm.

Steps

1. Reader reads the card. (2 min per card)
2. Group answers three worksheet questions: What raised our hackles? What would we check, and through which door? Who would we tell, and what would we say?
3. Facilitator circulates and listens. Do not hand out the answer key until each group has committed to an answer.
4. Debrief at the end (see Discussion). Reveal the key for any card the room argues about.

SCENARIO CARDS (PRINT AND CUT; EVERY CARD IS A FICTIONAL COMPOSITE)

Names and details are invented. Any resemblance to a real student is accidental. Change names if one matches a student in your room.

Card 1A Remote assistant

Tamsin is a sophomore. She gets a direct message on a social app: "Remote personal assistant for a busy professor. \$450 a week, flexible hours, no experience." The interview is a text chat. Two days later "the professor's office" mails a check for \$2,400 and tells her to deposit it, keep \$400 as her first pay, and buy \$2,000 of "supplies" from a vendor who only takes payment cards or gift cards.

Card 1B Half-price apartment

Luis needs a place near campus by August. He finds a two-bedroom listed at half the usual rent. The owner writes that he is out of the country, will mail the keys, and needs a \$900 deposit through a payment app today because "three other people are interested."

Card 1C Pay now or lose your classes

Hana's phone buzzes with a text from "[COLLEGE NAME] Bursar": "Your spring registration will be cancelled in 2 hours. Pay the \$215 balance at this link." It has a college logo and a shortened link.

Card 1D Sold-out show

Kwame wants a ticket to a sold-out show. A post says "two tickets, face value." The seller sends a screenshot of the confirmation, asks for payment as "friends and family" and says "I have eight other people waiting."

Card 1E The refund code

Beatriz is a returning student with two kids, taking evening classes. A caller says he is from financial aid, that her refund is ready, and that for security he is sending a code by text which she should read back to him. Her phone buzzes with a six-digit code.

Card 1F The status call

Yusuf is an international student. A call comes from a number that looks official. The caller says there is a problem with his student status and he must pay a fine today in gift cards or his record will be flagged. The caller is calm and uses his full name.

ROLE-PLAY PRACTICE (NO STUDENT PLAYS A VICTIM OR AN OFFENDER)

The Second-Channel Call. Pairs. Partner A practices the call to the known number from the college website. Partner B plays the office staff member who answers and helps. Staff always answers kindly and says something real, such as "I can see that message did not come from us, thank you for checking." A uses this script: "I got a text that says it is from your office about a balance. I did not click anything. Can you tell me my actual balance and whether anything is due?" Swap roles. No one plays the sender of the message.

FACILITATOR KEY

Reveal the key lines on each card only after groups commit. If the room splits on a card, treat that as a gift: say that real messages and fake ones can look the same, and that is why the habit relies on checking, and not on spotting.

CARD	WHAT TO LISTEN FOR
IA Remote assistant	Signals: easy high pay, chat-only interview, a check she must send money from. Check: ask [CAREER SERVICES], look up the professor on the college directory, call the department number printed on the college site. A bank may show the deposit before the check clears, and it can bounce later [VERIFY]. Do not send money.
IB Half-price apartment	Signals: price, no viewing, hurry, payment that cannot be reversed. Check: housing office listings, a live video tour with the address, county property records where available [VERIFY], search the listing photos and the owner's wording elsewhere.
IC Pay now or lose your classes	Signals: two-hour deadline, link, threat. Check: open the student portal by typing the address or using the official app, and look at the balance there. Call the bursar's number from the college website. Report the text to [IT SECURITY] so others are warned.
ID Sold-out show	Signals: screenshot as proof, payment with no protection, hurry. Check: ask the seller to transfer the ticket through the official ticketing app so you see it land in your own account; use the venue's resale option if it has one.
IE The refund code	Signals: unsolicited call, a code she did not ask for. That code is a login or reset code for her own account, and reading it aloud hands over the key. Check: hang up and call the financial aid number listed on the college website. Real staff do not need her codes.
IF The status call	Signals: threat about status, gift cards, a demand to act today. Check: hang up and go to the international student office in person or by the phone number on the college site. Real government and college offices do not take payment in gift cards [VERIFY]. Facilitator: say plainly that fear of status problems is exactly what this scam uses, and that the office exists to help students who get these calls. Do not speculate about immigration rules.

Discussion (8 minutes)

- Which pressure signals showed up most often across the cards? Which were easiest to miss?
- What makes it hard to Pause when a message says you have two hours? What would help? (Take two or three answers.)
- Where is the second channel on this campus: which phone number, which office, which portal? Does everyone know where [FINANCIAL AID OFFICE] is?
- What would make it normal in your residence hall, your class group chat or your family to say "I think I just got scammed"?
- Optional, with Pass allowed: has a message like these ever reached you, and what did your hackles tell you?

Takeaway (read aloud, then hand out the evaluation card)

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
When a message wants speed, secrecy or an odd way to pay, pause and check through a door you opened yourself, then tell someone. If you were fooled, it was a professional's work, and the next step is the first-hour list.	

If a student discloses

TO VERIFY

Never promise confidentiality you cannot give. Title IX responsible-employee duties and campus reporting rules vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and state law]. Before the session, find out which category you are in, and say so to students.

Master steps (the same in every session):

1. **Say the heads-up first.** If a student starts to tell you something personal, pause them kindly before the details: "Thank you. Before you go on, I want you to know what I can and cannot keep private. [As a staff member I may have to share some of this with the Title IX office. COUNSEL TO CONFIRM your role.] If you would rather talk with someone who can keep it confidential, I can walk you to [COUNSELING CENTER]." Then let the student choose.
1. **Listen and believe.** Stay calm. "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault." Skip the "why" questions. Let the student use their own words.
1. **Do not investigate.** Ask only what you need to connect them with help: are you safe right now, and what would help most today? Never ask to see images, messages or accounts. Do not contact the other person.
1. **Never promise confidentiality or outcomes you cannot give.** Say what you will do and who you will tell. Responsible-employee duties under Title IX and campus policy vary by institution and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY current federal rules and your state law].
1. **Offer choices.** Counseling, a victim advocate, the Title IX office, campus police, the platform's report form, or none of these today. The student decides what to do next whenever the law and policy allow.
1. **Make a warm handoff.** Offer to walk with them, sit beside them during the call, or help write the email. A phone number on a card is a weaker handoff than a person.
1. **Safety first.** Immediate danger: 911 or campus police. Thoughts of suicide or self-harm: stay with the student, bring in the counseling center or a crisis line, and use 988 (call or text 988) or Crisis Text Line (text HOME to 741741).
1. **If a minor is involved** (an image of someone under 18, or a child at risk), reporting duties may apply to you as an adult, and they differ by state and role [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM; VERIFY state law]. Do not copy,

forward or screenshot such an image. Direct the student to NCMEC's CyberTipline and Take It Down.

1. **Write it down afterward.** Record the student's words and what you said and did, as your policy requires. Share with others only on a need-to-know basis. Talk with your supervisor about what you heard so you are not carrying it alone.

Specific to this session:

- A student may disclose a financial loss, identity theft, or an ongoing threat tied to a scam. Treat shame as the main enemy: say "thank you for telling me, this happens to careful people."
- Connect them to their bank or card issuer first, then [FINANCIAL AID OFFICE] or [DEAN OF STUDENTS] if aid or tuition is affected, then reportfraud.ftc.gov and identitytheft.gov [VERIFY]. A student in financial crisis can also be pointed to [EMERGENCY AID OR BASIC NEEDS OFFICE, if any].
- If the scammer is now threatening the student or has intimate images, move to the Session 5 protocol the same day.

Accessibility and inclusion notes

For this session:

- Card 1F can be heavy for students with immigration worries. Offer a Pass for that card, and keep the international student office's contact visible.
- Card 1E is written so a parent is not the butt of the joke. Keep the tone respectful when it is discussed.
- Students who rely on screen readers can open the cards as plain text from the slide notes or the printed set.

For every session:

- **International students.** Scam scripts, institutions and legal systems differ by country, and some scams exploit visa fears. Say plainly that a real college or government office will not demand payment in gift cards, and point to the international student office as a place to check any message about status. Use plain English, avoid idioms, share slides ahead of time, and let students use a translation tool during activities. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM: any reporting duties that apply to international students' status information; do not speculate about immigration consequences in class.]
- **Students with disabilities.** Send slides and cards in advance in accessible formats (the decks are built with real slide titles, reading order and speaker notes). Use captions for any video. Read cards aloud

for anyone who wants that. Allow extra time. Disability services can advise on assistive technology. Do not require anyone to speak, write by hand or move around the room.

- **First-generation students.** Do not assume anyone knows how financial aid, housing contracts or campus offices work. Name the real office and what it does. Describe the normal process before you describe the scam version of it.
- **Students who are parents or caregivers.** Evening and commuter schedules often mean children in the background or a short window to attend. Allow children in the room for lecture portions where the content suits it, and offer the printed cards for take-home. Examples that involve a child's photos or school should be framed around the adult's choices.
- **Commuter and evening students.** Offer a recorded or self-paced version of the same content with the same cards [LOCAL: confirm your platform's accessibility and privacy settings]. Keep sessions on time. Provide the handouts as one page so they fit a bag or a phone screen.
- **Everyone.** Participation is always optional. Offer a Pass card, a written question box, and a clear way to step out and return. Use content notes before heavy material, and show no images of the harms discussed.

Local resource table (fill in before the session)

NEED	WHO	HOW
Immediate danger	911, or [CAMPUS POLICE EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call
Campus police, non-emergency	[CAMPUS POLICE NON-EMERGENCY NUMBER]	Call or walk in
Campus counseling center	[COUNSELING CENTER NAME, PHONE, LOCATION, HOURS] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM whether it is a confidential resource]	Call or walk in
Title IX office	[TITLE IX COORDINATOR NAME, EMAIL, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM how reports are handled]	Email or call
Dean of students or student affairs	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in
Financial aid and bursar	[OFFICE, PHONE, LOCATION]	Walk in or call the number on the college website
IT help desk and security	[HELP DESK PHONE, EMAIL, LOCATION]	Call or walk in
International student office	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Disability services	[OFFICE, PHONE]	Walk in
Health center or victim advocate	[NAME, PHONE] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM confidentiality]	Call
Suicide or crisis support	988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988; chat at 988lifeline.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Text-based crisis support	Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images shared or threatened (you were 18 or older when the image was made)	StopNCII.org	stopncii.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Intimate images made when you were under 18	NCMEC Take It Down	takeitdown.ncmec.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Sextortion, or any image of someone under 18	NCMEC CyberTipline	report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Blackmail and internet crime	FBI IC3	ic3.gov [VERIFY]
Scams and fraud	FTC	reportfraud.ftc.gov [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in kit]
Identity theft	FTC	identitytheft.gov [VERIFY]
Dating abuse and controlling relationships	loveisrespect	Call 1-866-331-9474 or text LOVEIS to 22522; loveisrespect.org [VERIFY before printing]

RE-VERIFY EVERY NUMBER AND address before printing. Hotline details marked **VERIFIED** were checked in the Hackles verification rounds dated 2026-10-05 and should still be re-checked before any print run.

Evaluation card (anonymous; print four per page)

Evaluation cards are anonymous. Do not collect names, student ID numbers or email addresses. Tally counts only (for example, how many students circled each number). Aggregate results can go to your supervisor; individual cards are recycled after tallying [LOCAL: confirm records policy].

Session 1: Scams that target students

- I feel more able to spot a problem like the ones we discussed today. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- I know where on campus I could go for help with this topic. (1 = not at all, 5 = very much) 1 2 3 4 5
- One scam signal I will watch for this semester is: _____
- What would make this session better?
- Anything you want the facilitator to know? (Do not include names or personal details.)

Facilitator reflection (after the session, for your own notes)

- What went well? What would I change in the timing?
- Which card sparked the best discussion?
- Did a student disclose? Did I follow the protocol and write it down? Who did I debrief with?
- Which local blanks still need filling in?

Sources and verification notes

- studentaid.gov and the claim that filing the federal aid application is free. [VERIFY]
- Fee-for-service offers about loan forgiveness. [VERIFY]
- Payment-method protections and reversal windows. [VERIFY]
- Gift-card demands as a sign of a scam. [VERIFY]
- County property records access. [VERIFY]
- Hotline and reporting details are taken from the kit's **VERIFY Checklist** and the 9-12 Teacher Guide appendix C1. Re-check before printing.
- Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. It does not replace campus counseling, Title IX processes, legal advice or emergency services.

